The final day of the last Test is tense and India are chasing a reachable target. As darkness threatens to descend on South London, we finally run through their batters in the afternoon but they still have time to hold on to draw. Joe Root asks for a new ball and hands it to me. Mohammed Shami is batting. Cooky is at slip, his last moments as a Test cricketer dimming with the light. I run in and get the ball to move into him, missing his defensive stroke, his middle stump flying. It's my 564th Test wicket and with it I go past Glenn McGrath's total on the all-time list. Cooky runs up to me, his broad grin shining in my face, and hugs me, as if a huge torment has been lifted off him, and we walk off side by side, in conversation, just like that first flight. We have won 4-1.

I conduct the interview straight after with my first ever wicket, Ian Ward, who stands in front of me, microphone in hand as tears swell. 'You're going to miss him, aren't you?' he says. I feel the confusing mixture of exhaustion and emotion as I try to laugh off the tears. 'Absolutely, yeah,' I say, feeling the 12 years throw themselves into my chest. 'He's my best mate and …' I can't get the words out any more, pure emotion and heartbreak and gratitude finding their way out to penetrate through any sense of a normal post-match interview. 'He's been brilliant.' Every word feels like it takes an army to get out. 'Just to always be there for me.'

When alcohol has dulled our senses and eased the flow of words, Cooky is standing next to me in front of an emptied Oval. It's the last time we will be together with a series won, the ghosts of everything that has happened still inside the ground, and just the two of us understanding what we have been through. 'I think he's England's greatest ever cricketer,' Cooky says about me, deflecting from it all being about him. 'How many wickets has it been now, 564?' They both turn to me. I shrug: 'I've lost count.'

Kohli isn't one of them this year, but I can live with that.